

too, particularly in the chapter titled "A Lifetime before Sunday" and in small notes providing bulleted information with the aid of graphic devices featuring a paper-clip and scraps of paper. Saraswati is already dead or dying when we meet her in the prologue, so that takes care of suspense as well as the need to explain how we can enter the thoughts of some characters while simultaneously witnessing scenes in the lives of others.

Saraswati's beautiful sister Damayanti is married into the Bollywood film industry, with a husband and son who may be caricatures of Bachchans Senior and Junior just as the bisexual novelist script-writer

EXCERPT

Damayanti devised this is as cute and quickly endearing to both, the filmy press and the audience; turned out she was right. Her husband and son have identical initials in name and surname, the latter is therefore K2. After the peaks mountain-climbers encounter in the Himalayan range, K1 and K2. The media finds this catchily promising: the father-son duo who will be better than, if not as good as, any Khanna or Khan clan in Bollywood. They too will blaze a trail, there will be grandsons. Lineage forms legitimacy. Legitimacy is legacy. Legacy is all.

Smeete may be a stand-in for celebrity novelist Shobhaa De. Dozens of other half-recognised characters fill out a convoluted tale involving filmi adultery, political scandals, abortions, rapes and births, presumably based loosely on the lifestyles of Page Three denizens. There's gratuitous sex—of course!—as well as scenes of gore torn directly from newspaper reports of riots, pogroms and the creeping menace of civil war. The book is so up-to-the-moment that even President Obama takes a brief bow within its pages.

Whatever, whoever. The true subject of the book is the author's violent need to communicate her views about history and politics, the forces that imprison poor struggling mortals in their grip and the ideals that can unlock the puzzle of existence. Her style is in-your-face abrasive yet her intentions are intelligent, honest and serious. I didn't like the book and will certainly not be looking forward to the next one, already announced in the end pages. Nevertheless, I hope there are crowds of readers for whom Virani's anger will be provocative, her ideas creative and her energy inspiring. For all the blood, sweat and fury, the novel ends on an optimistic note. Clearly, however dark her vision is, Virani believes that books like hers can make a difference. For her sake and for yours and mine, I hope she's right. ■

Field of Vision

He's a cross between cricket futurist and mad professor but his book is a letdown

| By Sharda Ugra |



THE FUTURE OF CRICKET: THE RISE OF TWENTY20
by JOHN BUCHANAN
Orient Paperbacks
Price: Rs 295
Pages: 191

The words 'Twenty20' and 'John Buchanan' are a trigger mechanism that cut right to the noise and dust of a crumbling edifice. In other words, the Kolkata Knight Riders' (KKR) second IPL season, which unravelled in spectacular high farce. So when former KKR coach Buchanan shows up as author of *The Future of Cricket: The Rise of Twenty20*, it seems that this is a spill-all account of the Season II Nightmare. Oh goody. Bring out the dirty laundry.

Well, this is not *that* kind of a book. It's more about Buchanan's vision of where the Twenty20 game should go.

Before his unfortunate KKR stint, the former Aussie coach was considered something between cricket futurist and Mad Professor. T20 cricket is, then, Buchanan's ideal laboratory. And naturally his suggestions are radical: indoor stadia, 15-strong playing squads, baseball-style batting and bowling cages near the dugouts, limiting bowlers' run-ups and a more central, powerful role for team owners (Mohit Burman for IPL commissar, anyone?). All ideas are worth a bar-room debate (bar Burman's elevation to dizzy heights, of course) but are lost in the static of this unstructured book. An untidy mix of chapters takes random turns discussing the Twenty20 format and Buchanan's IPL experience which, it seems, contained many lengthy conversations with Ajit Agarkar.

Despite an eager earnestness to fathom that unfathomable beast called Indian "culture", it's safe to say that Buchanan doesn't quite get it. It's not like he doesn't try, but the trying is often hugely off the mark (like going to Greg Chappell as a guide to working with Sourav Ganguly) or inadvertently comic ("In Australia when you greet people, you shake hands. But Indian greetings are different. They greet by hugs... Australians are accustomed to a certain degree of personal space but in India there is no such thing... In India, it is close up and personal all the time. So each time we met, Shah Rukh and I would hug").

So in between hugging SRK and putting off SG, Buchanan's plans for KKR ran aground. Much like the actual intention behind this rather rambling read. ■